

'Deepens our sense of the wonder that was India'

PANKAJ MISHRA



INDIANS

A brief HISTORY *of a*
CIVILIZATION



NAMIT ARORA

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François Bernier's India

(1658–69 CE)

‘The heat is so intense in Hindoustan, that no one, not even the King, wears stockings,’ writes Frenchman François Bernier (1625–88) in a letter to a friend back home in the 1660s. For over six months, ‘everybody lies in the open air without covering—the common people in the streets, the merchants and persons of condition sometimes in their courts or gardens, and sometimes on their terraces, which are first carefully watered’.¹ Bernier, a medical doctor, was then in Aurangzeb’s employ in Shahjahanabad, the new capital of the Mughal Empire in Delhi.

Eager to see the world, Bernier had left France in 1654 and spent a few years in Syria, Palestine, and Egypt, from where he made his way to Surat, Gujarat, in 1658. He stayed in India for twelve years, starting as the personal physician of Dara Shikoh, Emperor Shah Jahan’s eldest son. He was in Delhi during the bloody war of royal succession that saw Aurangzeb prevail over his three brothers and imprison his father Shah Jahan—a saga Bernier documented in extensive detail in a letter to a friend.

Bernier then worked for a nobleman in Aurangzeb’s court, Daneshmand Khan, secretary of state for foreign affairs and grand master of the horse. In his letters to people back home, later

published as *Travels in the Mogul Empire*, Bernier warmly refers to Khan as 'my Agah', 'the most learned man of Asia', 'whose thirst for knowledge is incessant', and who devotes his afternoons to 'philosophical studies... Astronomy, geography, and anatomy are his favourite pursuits, and he reads with avidity the works of Gassendi and Descartes'.

In his letter, Bernier criticizes Europeans who complain that the buildings in the Indies 'are inferior in beauty to those of the Western world, forgetting that different climates require different styles of architecture; that what is useful and proper at Paris, London, or Amsterdam, would be entirely out of place at Delhi'. 'In these hot countries,' he explains, a beautiful house is capacious, 'airy and exposed on all sides to the wind, especially to the northern breezes'. He adds, 'A good house has its courtyards, gardens, trees, basins of water, small *jets d'eau* in the hall or at the entrance, and handsome subterraneous apartments which are furnished with large fans, and on account of their coolness are fit places for repose from noon until four or five o'clock, when the air becomes suffocatingly warm . . . no handsome dwelling is ever seen without terraces on which the family may sleep during the night.' Bernier then describes the typical interiors of fine houses, their carpets, painted ceilings and flower pots. He describes the beauty of a few public buildings in Delhi, such as the Jama Masjid and the Caravanserai (demolished in the nineteenth century), as grand as the Palais Royale in Paris—'the rendezvous of the rich Persian, Usbek, and other foreign

merchants'.² 'I think it may be safely asserted, without disparagement to the towns in our quarter of the globe, that the capital of Hindoustan is not destitute of handsome buildings, although they bear no resemblance to those in Europe.' The Taj Mahal, he thinks, 'deserves much more to be numbered among the wonders of the world than the pyramids of Egypt'.

Bernier estimates the population of Delhi as not 'greatly less' than that of Paris. '[Besides] the Omrahs [noblemen], the city never contains less than thirty-five thousand troopers, nearly all of whom have wives, children, and a great number of servants, who, as well

as their masters, reside in separate houses,' he notes. 'The uniform and wide streets that so eminently distinguish Dehli [sic]' from the old Mughal capital Agra, 'are crowded with people . . . and, excepting a few carts, unincumbered with wheel carriages'. 'Omrahs and Rajas ride thither, some on horseback, some on majestic elephants; but the greater part are conveyed on the shoulders of six men, in rich Palekys, leaning against a thick cushion of brocade, and chewing their bet-lé, for the double purpose of sweetening their breath and reddening their lips.'

In summertime, a major fruit market sells expensive 'dry fruit from Persia, Balk, Bokara, and Samarkande; such as almonds, pistachios, and walnuts, raisins, prunes, and apricots; and in winter . . . excellent fresh grapes, black and white, brought from the same countries, wrapped in cotton; pears and apples of three or four sorts, and those admirable melons which last the whole winter'. Babur, who began the Mughal Dynasty, would have loved this market. He had terribly missed grapes and melons from Bukhara and Samarkand. He had tried to grow a few on the Indian soil and even had some success with it. In *Baburnama*, his urbane memoir, he writes, 'To have grapes and melons grown in this way in Hindustan filled me with content.'³ Clearly, he and his descendants weren't able to grow on Hindustani soil all of the grapes and melons they missed.

'To be considered a Mogol, it is enough if a foreigner have a white face and profess Mahometanism,' writes Bernier. The term 'Mogol' includes Persians, Turks, Arabs, Uzbeks and their descendants. The Persians are mostly Shia, the rest mostly Sunni. He contrasts the Mogols with others of darker complexion, the largest being the Gentiles (i.e., not of an Abrahamic faith), who have 'the languid manner of this country'. There are many ethnic and religious groupings but no 'Indian' identity. A hierarchy exists in which the Mogols heavily dominate the best imperial positions, besides a few Hindu Rajputs. The cavalry at the king's disposal, including 'those in the provinces, forms a total of more than two hundred thousand horse' and 'two, or even three hundred thousand infantry'. This includes 'servants, sutlers, tradesmen, and all those individuals

belonging to bazaars' who convey 'the immense quantity of tents, kitchens, baggage, furniture, and even women, usually attendant on the army', much of it using numerous 'elephants, camels, oxen, horses, and porters'. Even a subset of this army on the move is a spectacle to behold and a very disruptive—and economically lucrative—event for the locals.

Bernier describes the opulence of the emperor and his courtiers, their grand processions, bejewelled costumes, the audience hall at Red Fort with its peacock throne and lavish furnishings of silver, gold brocade, silk and satin. He observes 'the base and disgusting adulation which is invariably witnessed there' and 'the vice of flattery [that] pervades all ranks'. He describes the luxurious but cloistered lives of women in the Seraglio. Whereas Shah Jahan invited singing and dancing girls there, 'often detained them the whole night, and amused himself with their antics and follies', Aurangzeb doesn't do so. Bernier writes that Aurangzeb 'is more serious than his father' and 'anxious to appear a true Musulman'. His 'extremely liberal' and erudite brother Dara Shikoh, who translated the Upanishads into Persian, had called him a 'Nemazi', or "'that Bigot," that ever-prayerful one'. But Dara too had many flaws. Bernier thinks he was 'very irascible; apt to menace; abusive and insulting even to the greatest Omrahs' and undervalued 'the opinions of the wisest counsellors'. Whereas Aurangzeb possessed 'a sounder judgment, and was more skilful in selecting for confidants such persons as were best qualified to serve him with faithfulness and ability' and 'whose talents for government [his father] always entertained a high opinion'.

The common man's life, however, is very different. 'In Dehli there is no middle state. A man must either be of the highest rank or live miserably.' In Paris, 'seven or eight out of ten individuals seen in the streets are tolerably well clad, and have a certain air of respectability; but in Dehli, for two or three who wear decent apparel, there [are] seven or eight poor, ragged, and miserable beings'. All in all, he tells his friend, 'I may indeed say, without partiality, and after making every allowance for the beauty of Dehli, Agra, and

Constantinople, that Paris is the finest, the richest, and altogether the first city in the world.'

Among the things he misses from home is bread. Bakers 'are numerous,' he writes, 'but the ovens are unlike our own, and very defective. The bread, therefore, is neither well made nor properly baked.' Liquor is forbidden, 'equally by the Gentile and Mahometan law', but secretly consumed. Wine is rare, and those imported by the Dutch 'are so dear that, as we say at home, the taste is destroyed by the cost'. Only a few Christians 'dare openly to drink' a tippale called Arac, which is 'harsh and burning'.

On the Social and Economic Conditions of 'Hindoustan'

'Of this vast tract of country,' Bernier writes, 'a large portion is extremely fertile; the large kingdom of Bengale, for instance, surpassing Egypt itself, not only in the production of rice, corn, and other necessities of life, but of innumerable articles of commerce which are not cultivated in Egypt; such as silks, cotton, and indigo.' Artisans manufacture 'carpets, brocades, embroideries, gold and silver cloths, and the various sorts of silk and cotton goods, which are used in the country or exported abroad'.

The king is the proprietor of all land in the kingdom, writes Bernier (Megasthenes also noted this in Mauryan times). He asks 'whether it would not be more advantageous for the King as well as for the people, if the former ceased to be sole possessor of the land, and the right of private property were recognised in the Indies as it is with us? I have carefully compared the condition of European states, where that right is acknowledged, with the condition of those countries where it is not known, and am persuaded that the absence of it among the people is injurious to the best interests of the Sovereign himself'. Lack of formal property rights, argues Bernier, deters people from investing in their lands and homes to improve their lot, since they may lose them based on the whims of power. This, in turn, depresses tax revenues and encourages people to hide

their surpluses in gold. (In his day, expanding property rights and waning feudalism had in recent centuries put Europe on a heady new path of economic and cultural evolution.)

Provincial governors and tax collectors, writes Bernier, 'have an authority almost absolute over the peasantry, and nearly as much over the artisans and merchants of the towns and villages within their district; and nothing can be imagined more cruel and oppressive than the manner in which it is exercised'. Therefore, if and 'when wealth is acquired [by a commoner], the possessor, so far from living with increased comfort and assuming an air of independence, studies the means by which he may appear indigent: his dress, lodging, and furniture continue to be mean, and he is careful, above all things, never to indulge in the pleasures of the table. In the meantime, his gold and silver remain buried at a great depth in the ground'.

This 'miserable system of government', mixing despotic power with lack of private property, went beyond the Mughal realm and was said to be pan-Asian. What Bernier refers to was an Indian system of non-hereditary feudal land tenure that arose in Gupta times. This system, according to Bernier, explains why 'most towns in Hindoustan are made up of earth, mud, and other wretched materials' and the 'decline of the Asiatic states', presumably relative to Europe's rising fortunes in its age of exploration and colonization. His account reveals a powerful extractive bureaucracy concentrating riches at the top, sustaining a huge army and funding the lavish lives of the aristocrats, not to mention 'the enormous expenses of the Seraglio, where the consumption of fine cloths of gold, and brocades, silks, embroideries, pearls, musk, amber and sweet essences, is greater than can be conceived'. Millions, he writes, 'depend for support solely on the King's pay. Is it possible, [as many] have asked, that any revenue can suffice for such incredible expenditure?' They seem 'to forget the riches of the Great Mogol, and the peculiar manner in which Hindoustan is governed'.

Consequently, 'the inhabitants have less the appearance of a moneyed people than those of many other parts of the globe'. Bernier's portrait of the extreme disparities in India agrees with the

testimony of Athanasius Nikitin, a Russian traveller in the fifteenth century: 'Those in the country are very miserable, whilst the nobles are extremely opulent and delight in luxury.' This is at odds with the *sone ki chidiya* (golden bird) imagery often invoked about precolonial India, likely based on the accounts of foreign travellers who hobnobbed with the social elites and reported on their great wealth—even as the commoners were no better off than in other parts of the world.

Further, as Bernier writes, much of the oft-remarked fabulous wealth of Hindoustan existed in gold, diamonds, and 'a prodigious quantity of pearls and gems of all kinds, of great size and value'. Bernier doubts 'whether any other Monarch possesses more of this species of wealth . . . But all these precious stones, and valuable articles, are the spoils of ancient princes, Patons and Rajas, collected during a long course of years, and, increasing regularly under every reign'. However, Bernier astutely points out, 'upon the security of [such wealth] the King, in a time of pressing necessity, would find it extremely difficult to raise the smallest sum'.

Given all this, Bernier asks, 'Can it excite wonder, that under these circumstances, the arts do not flourish here as they would do under a better government, or as they flourish in our happier France? No artist can be expected to give his mind to his calling in the midst of a people who are either wretchedly poor, or who, if rich, assume an appearance of poverty, and who regard not the beauty and excellence, but the cheapness of an article.' Bernier believes that the arts of the Indies 'would long ago have lost their beauty and delicacy, if the Monarch and principal Omrahs did not keep in their pay a number of artists'.

Moreover, a 'profound and universal ignorance is the natural consequence of such a state of society'. 'Is it possible,' asks Bernier, 'to establish in Hindoustan academies and colleges properly endowed? Where shall we seek for founders? Or, should they be found, where are the scholars? Lastly . . . where are the benefices, the employments, the offices of trust and dignity, that require ability and science and are calculated to excite the emulation and the hopes of the young student?' As if this wasn't enough social

anthropology to reckon with, Bernier also seems to have anticipated Adam Smith, born thirty-five years after his death in 1688:

Nor can the commerce of a country so governed be conducted with the activity and success that we witness in Europe; few are the men who will voluntarily endure labour and anxiety, and incur danger, for another person's benefit—for a governor who may appropriate to his own use the profit of any speculation.

. . . to conclude briefly I must repeat it; take away the right of private property in land, and you introduce, as a sure and necessary consequence, tyranny, slavery, injustice, beggary and barbarism: the ground will cease to be cultivated and become a dreary wilderness; in a word, the road will be opened to the ruin of Kings and the destruction of Nations. It is the hope by which a man is animated, that he shall retain the fruits of his industry, and transmit them to his descendants, that forms the main foundation of everything excellent and beneficial in this sublunary state; and if we take a review of the different kingdoms in the world, we shall find that they prosper or decline according as this principle is acknowledged or contemned: in a word, it is the prevalence or neglect of this principle which changes and diversifies the face of the earth.

Bernier accompanies Aurangzeb's large entourage to a retreat in Kashmir, 'one of the most beautiful countries in the world'. The Kashmiris, he writes,

are celebrated for wit, and considered much more intelligent and ingenious than the Indians. In poetry and the sciences, they are not inferior to the Persians. They are also very active and industrious [and] proverbial for their clear complexions and fine forms . . . The women especially are very handsome; and it is from this country that nearly every individual, when first admitted to the court of the Great Mogol, selects wives or concubines, that his children may be whiter than the Indians and pass for genuine Mogols.

Near Kashmir Bernier also meets a leader from the 'Lama tribe' of Tibet, led by a very old 'Grand Lama', who, nearing death, 'assembled the council, and declared to them that his soul was going to pass into the body of an infant recently born'. Buddhism had disappeared from India to such an extent that Bernier didn't even recognize them as adherents of a faith with roots in India.

On Ridiculous Errors and Strange Superstitions

‘Bernier was very much the educated European of the early Enlightenment,’ writes historian William Dalrymple in *City of Djinns*. ‘He knew his classics, was a firm believer in Reason, and had no patience with “ridiculous errors and strange superstitions”.’ Bernier studied physiology and philosophy under the materialist Pierre Gassendi and was a man of the emerging scientific–philosophical thought of Europe. He felt part of a more ‘advanced’ civilization, both in terms of its scientific knowledge and its social and political thought.

Consequently, in his letters, he is often dismissive of Indians and their beliefs, especially Gentiles (who were more alien to him, whereas he had access to Europe’s considerable body of knowledge and attitudes on Muslims). ‘[The] Gentiles understand nothing of anatomy,’ he writes. ‘They never open the body either of man or beast, and those in our household always ran away, with amazement and horror, whenever I opened a living goat or sheep for the purpose of explaining to my Agah the circulation of the blood [recently explained by William Harvey].’

In another letter, he tries to show ‘that there is no doctrine too strange or too improbable for the soul of man to conceive’, citing examples from Gentile India (and a few from France). During a solar eclipse, he watches ‘deluded people’ plunge themselves in the Yamuna and ‘perform their silly tricks until the end of the eclipse’. Then they ‘gave alms to the Brahmens, who failed not to be present at this absurd ceremony’. He ridicules the logic behind these acts, which, he is told, derives from the four Vedas.

These books, he writes, also ‘enjoin that the people shall be divided, as in fact they are most effectually, into four tribes [that] are not permitted to intermarry, that is to say, a Brahmen is forbidden to marry a Quettery [Kshatriya], and the same injunction holds good in regard to the other tribes’. Another contemporary French traveller, Jean Baptiste Tavernier (1605–89), also writes about India’s caste divisions. ‘An idolater will not eat bread nor drink water in a house belonging to any one of a different caste from his own, unless it is

more noble and more exalted than his own.' One caste, Haldrkkors, is 'only occupied in removing the refuse from houses, it gets the remains of what the others eat, of whatever caste they may be, and it does not make any scruple about eating indifferently of all things.

[Its members] alone feed pigs and use them for food'.⁴

With barely concealed horror, Bernier also relates events from the famous 'car' festival of the Jagannath Temple in Orissa (similar to the chariot festival described by Niccolo de Conti in Vijayanagar):

A superb wooden machine [with] many grotesque figures . . . is set on fourteen or sixteen wheels like those of a gun-carriage, and drawn or pushed along by the united exertions of fifty or sixty persons. The idol, Jagannat, placed conspicuously in the middle, richly attired, and gorgeously adorned, is thus conveyed from one temple to another . . . blindly credulous [people] throw themselves upon the ground in the way of its ponderous wheels, which pass over and crush to atoms the bodies of the wretched fanatics without exciting the horror or surprise of the spectators. No deed, according to their estimation, is so heroic or meritorious as this self-devotion: the victims believe that Jagannat will receive them as children, and recall them to life in a state of happiness and dignity.

Bernier derides Brahmins who 'promote these gross errors and superstitions to which they are indebted for their wealth and consequence'. Though 'held in general veneration', 'their tricks and impostures' are 'wicked and detestable'. 'Lustful priests' even deceive and possess young girls dedicated to serve the deity at Jagannath Temple. He claims, 'The Great Mogol, though a Mahometan, permits these ancient and superstitious practices; not wishing, or not daring, to disturb the Gentiles in the free exercises of their religion.'

He then focuses on the 'melancholy fact' of sati, relating many harrowing cases that he has seen. He is certain that many widows 'would willingly have recanted, if recantation had been permitted by the merciless Brahmins; but those demons excite or astound the affrighted victims, and even thrust them into the fire'. Citing an example, he writes that a young woman on the burning pyre was 'prevented from escaping by the long poles of the diabolical executioners'. In another, the Brahmins pushed 'the unwilling victim toward the fatal spot, seated her on the wood, tied her hands and feet, lest she should run away, and in that situation the innocent creature was burnt alive'. Bernier doesn't mince words, 'I need

scarcely say how much my own indignation has been excited, and how ardently I have wished for opportunities to exterminate those cursed Brahmens.’ He clarifies, too, that any widow who manages to ‘avoid the impending sacrifice, cannot hope to pass her days in happiness, or to be treated with respect or affection . . . she is ever afterwards exposed to the ill-treatment of her low and vulgar protectors’. Women became satis mostly among upper-caste Hindus, especially warrior elites, who appeared more often in Bernier’s milieu. Notably,

. . . the Mahometans, by whom the country is governed, [do] all in their power to suppress the barbarous custom. They do not, indeed, forbid it by a positive law, because it is a part of their policy to leave the idolatrous population, which is so much more numerous than their own, in the free exercise of its religion; but the practice is checked by indirect means. No woman can sacrifice herself without permission from the governor of the province in which she resides, and he never grants it until he shall have ascertained that she is not to be turned aside from her purpose: to accomplish this desirable end the governor reasons with the widow and makes her enticing promises; after which, if these methods fail, he sometimes sends her among his women, that the effect of their remonstrances may be tried. Notwithstanding these obstacles, the number of self-immolations is still very considerable, particularly in the territories of the [Rajput] Rajas, where no Mahometan governors are appointed.

Tavernier too notes the official restraints Bernier describes above. A woman, Tavernier writes, ‘cannot burn herself with the body of her husband without having received permission from the Governor of the place where she dwells, and those Governors who are Muhammadans, hold this dreadful custom of self-destruction in horror, and do not readily give permission’. It is then curious, writes Romila Thapar, that in the nineteenth century people would start believing that sati ‘was necessitated by the “Muslim invasions” when upper-caste Hindu women had to defend their honour from Muslim marauders’.⁵ In fact, the first-known cases of sati in India date from mid-first millennium BCE, long before the birth of Islam.⁶

Bernier refuses to believe, as some apologists of sati claim, that ‘an excess of affection was the cause why these women burn

themselves with their deceased husbands'. He believes it's 'the effect of early and deeply rooted prejudices'. 'Every girl is taught by her mother that it is virtuous and laudable in a wife to mingle her ashes with those of her husband, and that no woman of honour will refuse compliance with the established custom. These opinions men have always inculcated as an easy mode of keeping wives in subjection, of securing their attention in times of sickness, and of deterring them from administering poison to their husbands.'

Bernier also expresses his dislike for the 'endless variety of Fakires, or Derviches, and Holy Men, or Gentile hypocrites of the Indies'. He speaks of a group 'seated or lying on ashes, entirely naked [with] hair hanging down to the calf of the leg, twisted and entangled into knots, like the coat of our shaggy dogs . . . several who hold one, and some who hold both arms, perpetually lifted up above the head; the nails of their hands being twisted, and longer than half my little finger'. At first, they remind Bernier of 'the ancient and infamous sect of Cynics', but he only sees in them 'brutality and ignorance' and 'vegetative rather than rational beings'. He rues that 'novices wait upon these fanatics, and pay them the utmost respect, as persons endowed with extraordinary sanctity'.

Bernier has seen 'bands of these naked Fakires, hideous to behold', who 'shamelessly walk, stark naked, through a large town' with 'frightful hair' hung loose or 'twisted round their heads'. He recalls one 'celebrated Fakire, named Sarmet, who paraded the streets of Dehli . . . He despised equally the promises and the threats of Aureng-Zebe, and underwent at length the punishment of decapitation for his obstinate refusal to put on wearing apparel'. The fakirs' public nudity seems to curtail Bernier's sympathy for them, though he is also disgusted by what he sees as their ignorance, superstition and lack of piety, evident in their painful austerities and fasting for days in order to seek union with God.

Piety mattered to Bernier because he was also a proud Christian and shared the historical European antipathy towards Islam. From his account, it's clear that he favours the 'establishment of missions, and the sending forth of learned and pious missionaries'. 'They are absolutely necessary,' he says. Christians ought to 'supply every part

of the world with men bearing the same character and following the same benign object as did the Apostles . . . promoting the glory of their REDEEMER'. Bernier expects some Gentiles to convert, but about Muslims he says, 'It is in vain to hope, however, that they will renounce the religion wherein they were born, or be persuaded that Mahomet was a false prophet . . . To counteract [Islam's] baneful progress, Christians must display the zeal.'

Bernier also had many discourses with Gentile scholars, including 'the six most learned Pendets' of Varanasi, but nothing seems to have impressed him. He concedes that some of their hypotheses 'have an affinity to the theories of Democritus and Epicurus', but he claims their 'opinions are expressed in so loose and indeterminate a manner that it is difficult to ascertain their meaning'. This leads him to think that 'the Pendets neither comprehend themselves, nor can make [themselves] intelligible to others'. Instead, they only 'make a thousand foolish and confused observations'. He is bemused by their conception of the world as an illusion, and has no patience for their 'fine similes'. 'In vain will you look for any solid answer,' he declares.

He asks the six learned pandits of Varanasi for 'their opinion of the adoration of idols'. The pandits respond, 'Images are admitted in our temples, because we conceive that prayers are offered up with more devotion where there is something before the eyes that fixes the mind; but in fact we acknowledge that God alone is absolute, that He only is the omnipotent Lord.' Bernier doubts this explanation. He suspects 'it was so framed as to correspond with the tenets of Christianity. The observations made to me by other learned Pendets were totally different'. He needles another set of Brahmins that many of their practices aren't possible in colder climes, such as bathing in rivers, clearly showing that their religion is not universal—and therefore inferior. But the Brahmins see things differently:

'We pretend not,' they replied, 'that our law is of universal application. God intended it only for us, and this is the reason why we cannot receive a foreigner into our religion. We do not even say that yours is a false religion: it may be adapted to your wants and circumstances, God having, no doubt, appointed many different ways of going to heaven.' I found it impossible to convince them that the Christian faith was

designed for the whole earth, and theirs was mere fable and gross fabrication.

To the modern reader, this gives a sense of a series of frustrating engagements driven largely by Bernier's inability to step outside his own philosophical framework. He rarely doubts his own comprehension and certainties in religion. Instead, his response is to grossly misunderstand and ridicule, and declare much of what he hears as 'extravagant folly'. He doesn't read Sanskrit, yet calls all of their books full of 'fabulous trash'. In geography, he claims, 'They believe that the world is flat and triangular.' This would have been news to Alberuni, who came in the eleventh century, read texts in Sanskrit and characterized the Indians' knowledge systems far more intelligently before evaluating them.

Could it be that Bernier's views were coloured by popular beliefs and social practices—astrology, superstitions, sati, naked fakirs, otherworldly attitudes, etc.—that vexed his humanistic sensibilities, and which then led him to dismiss that entire edifice of philosophies that he saw as enablers? Perhaps he didn't meet the best scholars. In India, Bernier 'is simultaneously attentive and dismissive, curious and contemptuous', writes philosopher Justin E.H. Smith, adding another nuance in noting that 'his negative judgments flow from his status as a libertine materialist philosopher in the battle against superstition back home in Europe'.⁷

Bernier triumphantly concludes, 'If the renowned sciences of the . . . Indies consisted of all the extravagant follies which I have detailed, mankind have indeed been deceived in the exalted opinion they have long entertained of their wisdom.' This may have been a valid critique had Bernier arrived at it through an adequate understanding of the subject. Instead, he mostly illustrates the difficulties inherent in a dialogue between disparate intellectual traditions.

Bernier's world view is familiar to us for its early modernity, humanism and materialistic ethos. He had his prejudices but he was also often remarkably clear-eyed. In Europe, his account fuelled the stereotype of 'oriental despotisms' among thinkers like James Mill, Hegel and Marx, who imagined Indians as unchanging, passive and

superstitious.⁸ Later, some others would see in his depiction the presence of ‘tolerance and coexistence of pluralistic subcultures’ in India.⁹

Bernier didn’t just travel through; for twelve years he worked and engaged with Indians with considerable openness. He wrote what is now a rare and insightful portrait of seventeenth-century India, decades before the arrival of European colonizers. In his account, India seems to be in a state of intellectual decay, uncreative and stunted, ill-prepared against the advancing power of Europe’s scientific method, mercantilism, scholarship and the nation-state model. He expressed fondness and affection for many people and things, but a good part of his account is an indictment of Indian society—though in ways that resonate aplenty with our own liberal assessments today.